sciences at Harvard, McGeorge Bundy, who became national security adviser, and the forty-four-year-old Harvard MBA and former president of the Ford Motor Company, Robert McNamara, who became secretary of defense. The president's brother, Robert, also a Harvard graduate, took the position of attorney general and became another key member of Kennedy's foreign policy team. Secretary of State Dean Rusk had gone to Oxford on a Rhodes scholarship. These four were the backbone of the president's foreign policy team, which also included representatives of the CIA and the armed forces, along with top officials from other departments.[7]

The president's foreign policy advisers spent most of the summer trying to deal with the Berlin crisis, analyzing it in terms of the "Poodle Blanket" scenario. It envisioned four phases of escalation over Berlin, the first beginning with Soviet interference with Allied access to West Berlin, the second resulting in a Soviet blockade of the city, the third leading to conventional warfare, and the fourth culminating in a nuclear exchange. The situation was considered to represent phase one, with the expectation that it might rapidly deteriorate. There were signs suggesting that the Soviets were preparing to escalate.

In a letter to Kennedy delivered to the White House on July 5, Khrushchev set forth his new demand for the gradual withdrawal of the Western allies from Berlin, promising a new era in Soviet-American relations if his proposal was accepted and threatening a global crisis if it was not. He wrote: "[F]urther delay in solving the questions connected with a German peace settlement would involve such a threat to peace which must be averted already now when it is not too late." Kennedy responded to Khrushchev's demand by voicing his concern that the situation in Berlin might lead to nuclear war despite the wishes of the leaders themselves. He wrote: "In reading the history of past wars and how they began, we cannot help but be impressed how frequently the failure of communication, misunderstanding and mutual irritation have played an important role in the events leading up to fateful decisions for war." Kennedy was referring to a recently published book by Barbara Tuchman, *The Guns of August*.[8]

Khrushchev unexpectedly signaled a retreat. On July 25 he suggested to the US ambassador in Moscow, Llewellyn Thompson, that he "personally ask President—not through State Department whether it would be better for